2019

SELL MORE WITH THESE SALES TIPS

NEW, UPDATED, TRIED AND TESTED SALES TIPS (AND SOME OLDER ONES THAT STILL WORK)

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Eberhard Niklaus has over 40 year's sales experience. He has been extensively involved in selling as well as sales management. His passion for sales motivated him to publish a book in 2009 entitled "Successful Selling Unlocked – Relationship Marketing". An updated, revised edition has been made available in 2019, with the new title "Successful Selling Unlocked – Relationship Selling" (see USEFUL RESOURCES at the end of this book for more details)

Eberhard's passion for selling also makes him an exceptional sales trainer, as he draws on his many years of experience when running his various sales workshops (more details of these workshops are also available under USEFUL RESOURCE at the end of this book)

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INTRODUCTION

I published a book entitled “Successful Selling Unlocked – Relationship Marketing” in 2009 (the revised e-book edition in 2019 replaced the last word “Marketing” with “Selling”).

The purpose of that book is to help sales people understand how to use Relationship Selling to adapt to the changes which have occurred in selling over the last two decades. Today’s customers do NOT want to deal with sales people who simply want to sell a product or service. They want to deal with problem solvers.

The buzz words in sales are now “Relationship Selling” and “Consultative Partnerships”. Your customer wants to see you as a trusted consultant, who both understands their needs, and have the skills to solve their needs.

The purpose of this book is to inspire you with stimulating ideas for getting more sales. Some of the tips are taken from my book “Successful Selling Unlocked – Relationship Selling”.

I have also included some exercises which you can do in this book, making it practical and hands on to start using some of the skills and techniques discussed in this book.

And as I always say, above all, HAVE FUN!

Sales Tip 1: Selling isn't Telling

One of the most important sales skills is to be a good listener. Yet, one of the most common mistakes made by sales people is to talk too much. Sales people talk instead of listening to their customers. And when they do listen, they mostly suck at it!

Quickly answer these questions (don't re-read the question; your customer only asks a question once, and you are then required to answer them):

- "If an airplane crashed on the **exact border** between two countries (say in a river), **where** would unidentified survivors be buried, in the country the plane was travelling **to, or from**?"
- "How many animals of **each species** did Moses take aboard the ark with him?"
- "Is there any law against a man's marrying his widow's sister?"
- "The Bulls and the Stormers each play 5 rugby games. Both teams win 3 games each. How come?"

Ok, let us take a closer look at how your listening skills performed:

In the first question, if you guessed a country for the burial, you will likely find that the *survivors* strongly protested that you wanted to bury them (unless your listening skills picked up on that one, in which case, well done!)

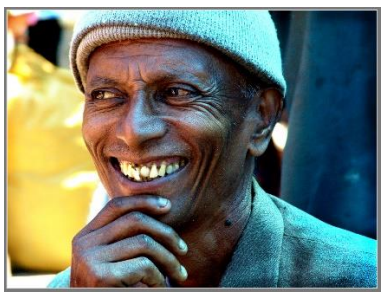
With the second question, it wasn't *Moses* who built the ark, it was Noah☺

If you answered "No" to the next question, you are correct. However, it would be the neatest trick of the week for a man to marry his *widow's sister*, because for him to have a widow, he would have to be dead.

Finally, who said the Bulls and the Stormers played against each other?

If you failed to answer all the questions correctly, you will agree that the biggest room in the world is the "room for improvement"

Listening is a skill that requires lots and lots of focused concentration, and practice, practice, practice! Listening requires focus (on the words, tone of voice, facial expressions and body language)



Sales Tip 2: Build Trust

A well-known statistic indicates that you need to contact someone **5 to 7 times** before they will buy from you. This process is required in order to build trust with your customer.

Here are some more sales statistics:

48% of sales people never follow up with a prospect.

25% of sales people make a second contact and stop.

12% of sales people only make three contacts and stop.

Only 10% of sales people make more than three contacts.

2% of sales are made on the first contact.

3% of sales are made on the second contact.

5% of sales are made on the third contact.

10% of sales are made on the fourth contact.

80% of sales are made on the fifth to twelfth contact.

So let me ask you, are you surprised when you call on 100 prospects once, and only close 2% of sales? Would it not be better to call on 100 prospects ten times, and then increase your sales to 80%?

Regular, meaningful contact with prospects will build trust and convert them to your customer!

TRY THIS:

- **Write down 20 prospects (ideal customers), and plan to contact them 7 times, adding value at each contact. Watch your sales grow!**

Sales Tip 3: Questions are the Answer

To fully understand the customer's needs, a sales person needs to be effective with questioning techniques.

Open-ended questions are useful for uncovering their needs. Open-ended questions cannot be answered with a Yes or No, and thus provide more information, which is what the sales person wants to achieve in this stage of the sale (Uncovering the Need).

Open-ended questions start with Why, What, When, Where, etc.

Let us use the example of a patient who visits there doctor due to an ongoing head ache. Here are some examples of open ended questions the doctor might ask:

- ✓ How long have you had the head ache?
- ✓ Describe it to me. What does it feel like?
- ✓ Where are you experiencing it?
- ✓ What have you tried using to fix it?

Probing questions are very useful to further establish their specific problems, identify concerns, and also to help the customer understand how your solution may be a fit for their needs:

- ✓ What frustrates you most about your current service?
- ✓ What's the best outcome I could help you achieve?
- ✓ What's the most important thing you're trying to achieve?
- ✓ What's the biggest obstacle for you right now?
- ✓ What's your biggest frustration right now?
- ✓ How would you feel if I could help you achieve….?
- ✓ What will make this meeting successful for you?

The art of skillful questioning, as with listening skills, requires you to visit that "biggest room in the world" - the "room for improvement", which entails that magical word once more – practice, practice, practice☺ (Sports stars practice many, many hours to perform at their best)

TRY THIS:

- ➢ **Write down 3 open ended questions which will help you uncover your customers' needs**

Sales Tip 4: Focus on the Function

What is the function of any organization? If you answered to make money or profit, you have confused the *function* with the *goal* of the organization. The function of any business, and by extension the sales person, is to "Get and keep customers".

Let me share an example of this with you. I read about someone in San Diego who received a flyer in his post box with a special offer from a local restaurant. The offer was for a piece of fish (yellow tail) and a salad for $7.95. He phoned the restaurant and placed his order, and they told him it would be ready in 20 minutes. When he arrived there 20 minutes later, they gave him an invoice for $9.95. Naturally the customer queried the price, showing them his flyer with the special offer. The manager asked him why he had not mentioned that he wanted the special offer, to which the customer responded that it had not occurred to him that it was necessary, and what difference would it make anyway? The manager explained that the fish for the special offer would be cut from nearer the tail, and would not be as fresh. The customer, who could see his fish frying as they spoke, asked the manager what would happen to his piece of fish if he refused to pay the higher price. The manager said he would either eat it or throw it away! The man walked out, and being a writer and motivational speaker, shared his unhappy experience with the specific restaurant in San Diego with thousands of people in the months to follow!

The manager of that restaurant may have thought he was doing the right thing for the owner of the restaurant. His mistake, though, was that he was focusing on the goal of the business (saving $2.00), rather than the function of the business (attracting and keeping customers). If he truly cared about attracting and keeping customers, he would not have lost another customer, and may well have received raving recommendations from a well-known and respected personality.

When your focus is on attracting and keeping customers, the goal of making a profit will automatically follow! Likewise, if a sales person focuses on helping their customers solve their needs, the goal of earning commission will automatically follow.

TRY THIS:

- **Write down three needs that your customers have, which you can focus on helping solve.**

Sales Tip 5: Finish the sales journey.

Many sales people are adept at uncovering customers' needs, offering a solution by referring to the relevant features and benefits, and addressing concerns (overcoming objections). However, even experienced sale people often hold off from finishing what they started, namely to close the sale. It is believed that the reason for this, even if only at a sub-conscious level, is because they fear rejection. What if the customer says "no"?

It is useful to remember that if you get a negative response to a closing attempt, it is the proposal being rejected, not you. It is also worth noting that a "no" you get today is not a "no" forever.

Performing the initial part of the sales process but holding back from attempting to close the sale is like going on a journey from point A to B, but stopping just short of point B for no reason whatsoever. Is that not crazy? When you don't close the sale on every sale (even if the close is unsuccessful, you completed the journey), you will lose out on many possible sales.

A close does not necessarily always mean closing an actual sale for your product or service. Sometimes the close is simply gaining agreement to proceed to the next stage of the sales process (especially in light of Tip 2).

Be ready to close whenever you detect a buying signal (any indication that the prospect is ready to buy). Even if you have more information you wanted to share with the person, proceed straight to the close (ask for the business). If you continue to talk after the person is ready to buy, you will usually talk your way out of a sale ☹

TRY THIS:

- **Write down three examples of a buying signal**
- **Write down three examples of a closing question**

GO ALL THE WAY!

Sales Tip 6: Talk Features and Benefits

An insurance sales person does not sell insurance. Well, she might think she does. However, she will sell more effectively if she understands what her potential customers are actually buying, which is peace of mind.

The pest control sales person is not selling pest control. He is selling a safe and healthy environment.

The car sales person is not selling a car. He is selling transport, or image, or convenience, depending on the specific customers' needs which need to be uncovered by the sales person (hence the need for great questioning techniques and listening skills referred to earlier).

When selling, many sales people talk about the features of their solution (product/service), and neglect to translate these features into the benefits the customer is looking for. It is therefore important to always refer to both the features and the benefits it brings to the customer, since that is what they are looking for. (A feature is something about the product or service, and the benefit is what it does for the customer)

As in the example of the car, there may be several benefits derived from your product/service. Only refer to the relevant ones as identified when uncovering the need. Think of your features and benefits as a menu (it is always a good idea to have them written down, since you may forget some of them). When presenting your solution, only select the appropriate features and benefits form your menu.

When presenting your solution to your customer, always refer to the intangible benefits they are looking for (safety, peace of mind, health, convenience). When they hear these benefits, they will know that your solution is the right one!

TRY THIS:

- **List at least 5 Features and Benefits of your product/service/company**

Sales Tip 7: The Law of Connection

One of the 21 Laws of Leadership in John C Maxwell's book is called The Law of Connection. In fact, he has been quoted as saying that in his opinion, it is the most important of the 21.

How well do you connect with others? Do you invest in yourself and in your personal development? Below follows a sample of some of the "25 Pleasing personality traits" listed by Napoleon Hill. Consider which ones you manifest, and which ones you can invest in developing:

- ✓ (PMA) Positive Mental Attitude. Open the door and allow yourself to display your skills and ambitions. Imagine that sales person presenting her proposal with confidence, gaining the interest of the prospect, because she is distinctively self-assured and confident
- ✓ Sincerity of Purpose. Starts with yourself and you will steadily grow in self-sufficiency. It will strengthen the other characteristics of your pleasing personality. What better compass could you have than a true and lasting dedication to your definite major purpose?
- ✓ Promptness of Decision. Successful people reach decisions definitely and quickly. An inability to do so can annoy and inconvenience others. Prompt decision making is a habit, and it is supported by your positive mental attitude, which give you confidence.
- ✓ Courtesy is nothing more than the habit of respecting other people's feelings under all circumstances, the habit of going out of one's way to help the less fortunate, the habit of controlling selfishness in all forms.
- ✓ Tact. There is a right moment and a wrong moment for everything. Tact is the habit of doing and saying the right thing at the right moment. Tact is so closely related to courtesy that you cannot practice one without the other. It is an invaluable skill, just as noticeable for its absence as for its presence.
- ✓ Tone of Voice. Speech is the method we use most often to express our personality. Controlling the tone of your voice so that it carries meaning beyond mere words is invaluable.
- ✓ The Habit of Smiling. Don't underestimate the importance of a frequent and sincere smile in making your personality appealing to others or its effect on yourself.
- ✓ Facial Expression. This is another facet of an attractive personality that goes together with your tone of voice and your smile. You can tell a great deal about what is going on in people minds by the expressions on their faces. The more you learn to be aware of and in control of your facial expressions the better you'll be able to interpret the expressions of others.
- ✓ Tolerance. Is the disposition to be patient and fair toward those whose opinions, practices, and beliefs differ from yours. Holding your mind open to new ideas and new information is not simply a way to make yourself more pleasing to be around. The more intolerant you are, the more you are closed off to the diversity of the world, which can flourish only when it is ready to accept new ideas.
- ✓ Frankness of Manner and Speech. Everyone resents people who use deception instead of dealing frankly with associates. Truly sound characters have courage to speak and deal directly with people, and they follow this habit consistently, even though it may at times be to their disadvantage.
- ✓ A keen Sense of Humor. A well-developed sense of humor aids you in becoming flexible and adaptable to the varying circumstances of life. It allows you to relax and remain human in the midst of pressure, instead of becoming cool and distant or angry and bitter. It keeps you from taking life too seriously.

- ✓ A Keen Sense of Justice is not merely a tool for gaining material rewards. It enhances every relationship. It discourage avarice and selfishness and give you a much better understanding of your rights, privileges, and responsibilities. With it, every aspect of an attractive personality grows stronger.
- ✓ The Appropriate Use of Words. People who achieve success do it by careful and attentive effort. Your use of language must reflect this quality just as astutely as any marketing plan. Do not litter your speech with curses, obscenities, or casual misusage. Instead make sure that you use words with precision and that they have force and power to convey your meaning with all the clarity you desire.
- ✓ Effective Speech. Enthusiasm is the core element of any speech, for it underlies your ability to bring the above aspects of good public specking into a harmonious whole. It is very hard for listeners not to be affected by genuine enthusiasm; it is contagious. If you have sincerity and true confidence in your definite major purpose, you will have no trouble giving demonstrable feeling to what you are saying, and that is the essence of effective speaking.
- ✓ Emotional Control. Building your desire for success into a burning obsession and embarking on your definite major purpose are the cornerstones of your efforts to gain emotional control. Each strengthens the other, and progress with one will mean progress everywhere.
- ✓ Alertness of Interest. You must be able to fix your interest for as long as the situation requires. If you cannot, the other aspects of attractive personality will be useless. You can pay other people no greater compliment than to concentrate your attention on them when they want it. Listening well is an even greater accomplishment than speaking well.
- ✓ Versatility. No matter how much you know about the field of your endeavor, unless you can display a general interest in the world at large, no one is going to find you attractive. Keeping yourself acquainted with the issues of the day and maintain a few pursuits other than your business. They will broaden your character and deepen your knowledge of yourself as well. If you understand yourself, you'll be better able to understand others, and they will appreciate you more for it.
- ✓ Fondness for People. Just as a dog can sense those who do or do not like dogs, people recognize very quickly whether they are dealing with someone who likes other people. They resent those people with a natural dislike for their fellows, and they are attracted to those who possess genuine enthusiasm.
- ✓ Humility. Arrogance, vanity, and egotism are never found in someone with an attractive personality. Don't mistake humility for timidity; true humility is a recognition that even the greatest folk are, in the scheme of human existence, only fragments of the whole. People who are strong in faith are always humble of heart, and these qualities are always mush admired.
- ✓ Clean Sportsmanship. Win without boasting, lose without squealing, and others will soon respect you. Your outside interests are a good place to cultivate this trait. Flexibility, tact, and humility will aid you in its display. Let your manner always be friendly, no matter what the outcome, and people will be glad to have worked with you.
- ✓ A Firm Handshake. This is a simple skill, but is invaluable at first impression and every time a contact is renewed. Make your grasp firm and friendly, not crushing. Be direct and assertive in your greeting, and people will associate those qualities with the whole of your personality.

Sales Tip 8: 4 Ways for a Business to Grow

There are 4 ways for any business to grow:

- ✓ Get more customers
- ✓ Keep existing customers
- ✓ Increase the value of each transaction (upselling)
- ✓ Increase the frequency of each transaction.

Did you notice that three of the four ways for growth have to do with your existing customers?

TRY THIS:

- **Write down the names of 5 existing customers to whom you could upsell right now (additional products or services for them to buy)**
- **Write down the names of 5 old customers whom you could contact right now to buy from you again**

Sales Tip 9: You are your biggest USP

A decade ago sales people were trained to highlight the USP (Unique Selling Proposition) to their prospective customers. One of the big changes that has taken place in selling is the advent of incredible communication and the world transforming into a global village. This has led to customers being more knowledgeable, and competitors duplicating your USP in double quick time, thus negating your advantage.

The one thing your competitor cannot duplicate is your relationship you have with your customer. The biggest difference your customer perceives between you and your competition is YOU!

Some of the tips mentioned earlier will serve you well in having a meaningful relationship with your customer. Let's repeat some of them:

- ✓ Your ability to connect with your customer
- ✓ Focusing on helping them solve their needs (If you are only thinking about earning your commission they will quickly sense it)
- ✓ Building trust
- ✓ Being a good listener

Invest (time and effort) in relationships with prospective and existing customers. Build trust. Add value. Be sincere. Be positive.

Be enthusiastic! Enthusiasm gives you a spring in your step, an air of self-confidence that whatever life throws at you, you will take in your stride. Others are attracted to your enthusiasm.

TRY THIS (to generate enthusiasm):

- **Write down a list of 10 reasons why it is good to be alive**
- **Write down a list of 10 reasons why others need your product or service**
- **Write down a slit of 10 reasons why it is important for you to succeed**

Once you have your three lists, read them each morning to boost your enthusiasm!

Sales Tip 10: Have exciting goals

I have often asked audiences to raise their hands if they could truly say they are inspired. Sadly, in most instances less than half the audience raise their hands. The most obvious reason for this is that they don't have goals that inspire them. Get inspired by setting goals that excite you!

One word of caution about setting goals. Whatever goal you set yourself, becomes a "ceiling" for you.

Let me illustrate this concept by using the example of one of my previous franchisees many years ago in the cleaning industry. This particular branch was struggling at the time, so I decided to visit them with a view to giving them some support. At one time during the discussion I asked them what their target for that month was. The reply was R16 000. I asked how they had arrived at the target, and it was explained that it represented a growth of 15% on the turnover for the same month the previous year (and 15% growth is acceptable to most business's after all, isn't it?). I drew their attention to the fact that only a few months earlier they had achieved R30 000 in one month, and that they should consider aiming at higher targets, as they had basis for believing that R30 000 was achievable. I reminded them of the "ceiling" principle. If they kept their target at R16 000, they may come close to that figure, or even achieve it, but will be unlikely to surpass it. They decided to adjust the target to R30 000, and guess what? They achieved R29 000 that month. Do you think they would have achieved that turnover if they were still aiming for R16 000? Unlikely!

Be aware that whatever goals you set for yourself, they will act as a mental ceiling. Hence expressions such as the following have evolved:

- Aim for the treetop, and you might reach the branches, aim for the moon, and you will clear the treetop.
- Shoot for the moon, even if you miss, you will land amongst the stars.

TRY THIS:

- **Write down 3 exciting goals that will make you wake up inspired each morning**

Sales Tip 11: Overcome Objections- ask "Why?"

Think about your standard response to an objection such as "It is too expensive". (Before reading on, think about how you currently would respond)

If your response is along the lines of starting to justify your price ("Oh, but we are the best", or "Yes, but we have been around for 10 years, and our service is the best", and so on), then you are basing your response on an assumption, namely that your prospect either has a cheaper quote, or believes the price is not justified in their mind.

It is worth noting that sometimes people have other reasons for raising a price objection. Perhaps there has been a **misunderstanding**. For example, they may have been referred to you for carpet cleaning by a neighbor who used your services. They know the neighbor's house is somewhat larger than theirs, but the price you quoted them was in fact more than the neighbor paid.

Or perhaps the objection is based on **doubt.** They are in fact happy to pay your price, but still have doubt that your product or service will solve their problem (they are thinking, "What if after paying this amount, I still have a problem?)

In both these cases, your standard response of justifying your price will not address their concerns. The ideal way to respond to any objection, is to first of all ask "Why?" in a tactful manner:

"May I ask, why do you feel the price is too high?" When they reply, you will instinctively know how to respond in an appropriate way.

In the case of the misunderstanding mentioned above, their response could have been to tell you that their neighbor paid less than you have quoted the, despite the neighbor having a larger house. When you investigate closer, you realize that the neighbor's house had been empty when you cleaned their carpet (they were moving in), and the price per room is substantially less when there is no furniture to move around. By simply clearing up the misunderstanding, you have addressed their concern about the price.

In the case of the objection being based on doubt, their response could have been to let you know that they are still not convinced. The best response in that scenario would be to mention additional relevant features and benefits to persuade them, and also to offer them testimonials from satisfied customers.

Whenever faced with an objection, simply start off by asking "Why?" The rest will be instinctive.

TRY THIS:

- **Role play with a colleague who raises an objection. Use the above tip to address their objection.**

Sales Tip 12: Your Attitude

Even if you were accomplished with all the above mentioned skills, you would not succeed in sales if you did not have the correct attitude. During challenging economic times, even sales people with lots of experience and superb sales skills, struggle to achieve their sales targets.

The reason for this is their belief system has convinced them that times are tough, and that everybody is struggling, and that people are not spending money. However, you always have the choice to change your beliefs, and attract different results. Even when times are tough, you will still find people and businesses that are thriving. And if they can, so can you!

Here are some examples of things that have shaped my positive attitude in more recent times:

- ✓ A few years ago, when Brian Joffe was still the CEO of Bidvest, one of South Africa's most successfully listed companies on the Johannesburg Stock Exchange (JSE), he was being interviewed on the radio by a financial journalist. As usual, the financial results of Bidvest, which had just been published, were very impressive, despite a severe economic downturn (in fact, the country had experienced a technical recession). Asked about the reason for their ongoing success, Brian Joffe responded by saying that as Bidvest, "we choose not to participate in a recession". That re-enforced my deliberate choice to focus on reasons for success, even when everyone else was being shaped by myriads of reasons for not being successful.
- ✓ About a year ago at a networking event, one of my previous mentors was giving a short speech to the audience, again during an economic downturn. He shared his personal belief with us: "Just because the economy of the country is shrinking, it does not mean that my personal economy has to shrink". Wow! Talk about attracting success.

As I go through my daily tasks and routine, I observe companies that are growing despite a depressive economy where the inclination of most people and companies is negative. Whilst other companies are laying off staff, they are recruiting. Whilst other companies are downscaling, they are moving into bigger premises. As I drive, I observe development after development, where inspired, positive people are planning to start new business's, or expand existing ones. I am reminded that even in a depressive economic climate, where the majority of people will give you all the reasons why their sales or businesses are struggling - "Oh, times are tough! Everyone I talk to tell me how difficult it is, and that business is slow!" - there are always success stories to focus on. The question is, what do you choose to make your focus? If you believe that times are tough and failure is inevitable, then that will be your result. On the other hand, if you choose to look at the companies that are growing, and people who are positive and achieving growth and success, then you are likely to attract similar results, based on your positive self-belief.

If your attitude is generally negative, you will find it virtually impossible to develop trusting relationships. You need to ensure that you regularly exert yourself in maintaining your positive attitude, just as a healthy and attractive garden requires ongoing care and attention.

Your positive attitude should be complimented by positive qualities that serve as a signal of your spirit, a demonstration of your personality, which attracts people to you, much as a light attracts insects.

A last word:

Richard Branson was once asked for the secret to his success. He answered with one word: Fun!

I imagine he meant that he had fun waking up each morning as he looked forward to achieving his exciting goals, and no doubt celebrated success along the way.

Why not choose to do something for fun each day? It may be treating yourself to a cup of coffee to celebrate a good sales call, or securing an important meeting with a prospect.

Enjoy what you do. Seek opportunities to have fun. It is great to wake up and look forward to what you do, knowing that you are going to have fun each day. Fun inspires a positive attitude.

HAVE FUN!!

USEFUL RESOURCES:

IF YOU ENJOYED READING THIS BOOK, YOU MAY WANT TO ENJOY READING THE EXPANDED VERSION OF THIS BOOK, ENTITLED "SUCCESSFUL SELLING UNLOCKED – RELATIONSHIP SELLING" (2019 REVISED EDITION). CLICK HERE TO ORDER THE E-BOOK.

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